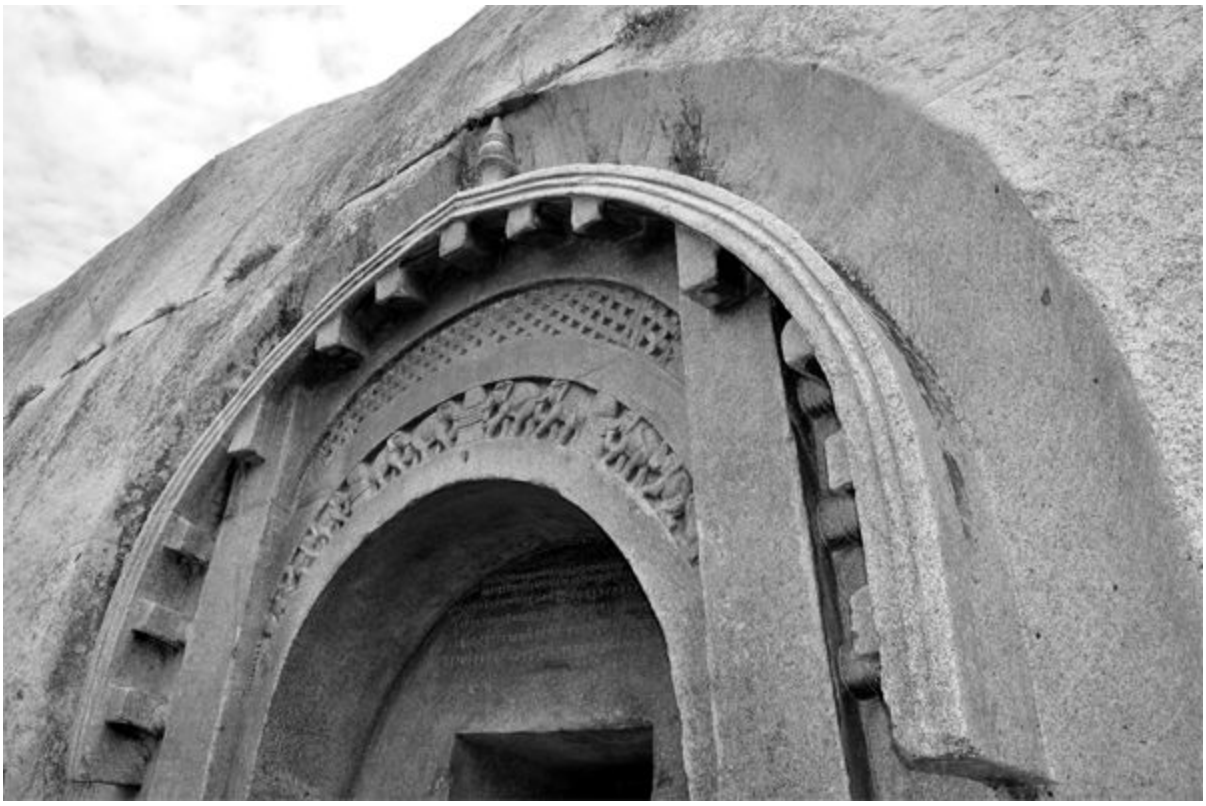


Fig 10.3: Lomasha Rishi cave architrave, with elephants moving towards a stupa

One may speculate that the frieze on the Lomasha Rishi cave—with its elephants and stupa and lattice frame design resembling that on the Mahabodhi throne gifted by Ashoka—signifies a cave for Buddhists. In that case, at Barabar Ashoka was creating dwellings for Buddhists, Ajivikas, and sundry sects and ascetics simultaneously, the Buddhist connection with Barabar becoming significant at a later period. Many centuries after, the ancient name of Barabar, Khalatika, was inscribed on a stupa at Kanaganahalli in Karnataka: ‘Galatiko pavato’ or ‘Khalatika parvata’ is mentioned on a label inscription engraved on one of the upper drum slabs of the stupa.[11] So by then Khalatika had been integrated within Buddhist stories, elements of which are usually depicted on stupas. At Khalatika itself there are no early Buddhist stupas or chaityas, the decorative aspects of the Lomasha Rishi cave indicating the only possible connection with Buddhism. Secular abode-donations at single locations were not unknown.